unleashed religious sentiments they could not control, for the first thirty years Islam was used primarily for instrumental purposes. This changed in July 1977 when General Zia ul-Haq seized power in a military coup d'état, after which he quickly declared martial law. During his reign, Zia promoted the expansion of Islamist influence in politics, the military and the civil bureaucracy.

General Zia's was not the first martial regime to govern Pakistan. More than half of the country's short history has been dominated by military rule, and even when not in power the army has exerted disproportionate influence on state policy from behind the scenes. There are several explanations commonly offered for the army's continued involvement—overtly and covertly—in Pakistan's governance. First, the nascent central government was unprepared for the refugee flows, communal violence and hostile geopolitical terrain that accompanied Partition. This led those in charge to cede much of the responsibility to the army, which set the tone for its future involvement in domestic affairs of state. Second, the new civilian leaders lacked legitimacy with the citizenry. The army, by virtue of its capabilities and its recognized position as the country's line of defense against India was viewed as the most legitimate actor in the country. Third, it has been argued that economic self-interest among members of the army contributes to its continued involvement in domestic affairs.[16] Ayesha Siddiqa, the Pakistani security analyst who posited this final explanation, asserts this involvement enabled the army to establish control over a vast economic empire, which it henceforth has sought to protect.[17]

The army historically has been a Punjabi-dominated institution, a development that can be traced back to a colonial pattern of military recruitment. During British suzerainty Punjabis were considered among the best soldierly material in the Indian colony. Soldiering opened up a major source of income since, on completion of military service, vast areas of arable land in Punjab were allocated to soldiers and veterans.[18] The result was a 'Punjabization' of the Indian army. Punjabis continued to dominate the army following Partition, though Zia helped to elevate the proportion of Pashtuns represented in its ranks.[19] Periods of military rule often witnessed a concomitant growth of Punjabi power, which in turn influenced Pakistani security priorities.[20] This is particularly true with regard to the Kashmir cause. Although it is generally less relevant to those living outside of